



Art History and Criticism 1 Honors

Art History and Criticism 1 Honors (Florida course 0100330) · Full year, delivered as two semester sections · The Great Conversation in images, from Greece to the moderns

~4¼ hrs
per week
50 min/day, M–F

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. Scholars may see some variation in artworks studied and projects from course to course, and between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Art history at Optima is taught as a long conversation: Giotto answers Byzantium, Caravaggio answers Mannerism, Picasso answers Cézanne. After a fall foundation in seeing, drawing, and the formal grammar of art, scholars walk the tradition in order, from Greek sculpture through Rome, the medieval world, the Renaissance, Baroque, Neoclassicism, Impressionism and Post-Impressionism, to the early moderns. This is a course in criticism as well as history: scholars learn to describe before they analyze and analyze before they judge, writing real critiques of real works. And they answer each era with their hands, making a piece in its manner, from a stained-glass painting to a Monet-inspired canvas to a Surrealist collage. VR experiences bring the works and their worlds close.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE — 36 WEEKS

Unit	Semester	What scholars study and make
Foundations of Seeing & Making	1	Why study art?; the Elements of Art; drawing fundamentals through Japanese art, Notan, pointillism, stippling, and Chuck Close grid portraits; Byzantine and Islamic art
Art Appreciation: How to Critique	1	The critic's sequence — describe, analyze, interpret, judge; practice critiques, then a choose-your-own-piece critique in VR
The Ancient & Medieval World	1	Greek sculpture (movement and emotion, then and now), Roman painting, the medieval era; make: a stained-glass painting
Renaissance → Baroque → Neoclassical	1–2	The rebirth of humanism; Baroque drama ("If It's Not Baroque, Don't Fix It!"); order, reason, and revolution; make: a Renaissance-inspired composition, water-droplet realism, "Doppelgängers Through Time"
Impressionism & the 19th Century	2	The Louvre and the Impressionist break; Post-Impressionism and Van Gogh; Sargent's <i>Madame X</i> ; make: a Monet-inspired painting, "Van Gogh at My Place," a profile portrait
Early Modern	2	Fauvism and Expressionism, Dada and Surrealism, Cubism to Abstraction, art and war; make: expressive color landscapes, a Surrealist collage ; year-end VR collaborative mural and gallery

THE TWO-WEEK CYCLE

Week	What the scholar does (~50 min/day, M–F)
Week 1 Learn & Look	A lesson page that opens with the era's masterworks, walked slowly; a sketch or looking assignment; a VR experience of the works and their world; a short auto-graded quiz.
Week 2 Make & Critique	The cycle's graded work: an artwork in the era's manner with a short artist statement, or a written critique of a real work using the describe–analyze–judge sequence.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes per week, the standard planning figure for Optima high-school courses: about 50 minutes a day, Monday through Friday. Looking and reading are half the work; making and writing are the other half. **Artwork and critique weeks** can run longer.

WHAT MAKES IT HONORS

- ▶ Real **art criticism** all year: scholars write structured critiques, not just reactions, and defend their judgments
- ▶ Every fact is real: artists, dates, and works are taught from the actual record, and scholars learn to verify claims about art
- ▶ Era-response artworks ask scholars to understand a style from the inside, by working in it

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- ▶ Basic studio materials: sketchbook, pencils, paper, and paint (the teacher's section confirms the supply list)
- ▶ A phone or camera to photograph finished work for submission
- ▶ **VR headset** for Optima's VR campus: era experiences, gallery walks, critiques, and the collaborative mural
- ▶ OneDrive (Microsoft 365) for critiques and the growing **portfolio** of era-response works

NOTES FOR FAMILIES

On-Demand (asynchronous). This course is designed for self-paced study with due dates for pacing. A teacher is available throughout for support, feedback on artwork and writing, and grading.

Live school. Scholars enrolled in the live school complete the same course in VR with a teacher and classmates on a regular weekly schedule.